

« For me, this auction wasn't about the money but about joining the right team »

DEEPAK CHAHAR

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Deepak Chahar is set to don the Mumbai Indians colours in the next Indian Premier League edition, marking the end of his seven-year stint with

Chennai Super Kings. Although he will miss the Chepauk dressing room and conversations with Mahendra Singh Dhoni, Chahar is excited to bowl alongside Jasprit Bumrah and Trent Boult at the Wankhede Stadium.

Chahar's ultimate goal is to return to the Indian team. He has bowled at full throttle in the Ranji Trophy and the Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy. "The more I bowl, the better I will get," he says in an interview with *Sportstar*.

As you start a new journey with Mumbai Indians, have you set any target?

I'm looking forward to playing for Mumbai Indians. Certain things are not in our hands, so my focus is on playing the entire domestic season, featuring in the IPL, and returning to the Indian team. Mumbai is a great place for me as Wankhede Stadium suits my bowling style, with swing

and seam movement on offer. I aim to perform consistently, stay fit, and ultimately return to the national fold. Everyone dreams of donning the Indian colours, and I hope to achieve that by giving my best.

This time around, when the mega auction was underway, did you watch the bidding war on television? How did you control your emotions?

For me, this auction wasn't about the money but about joining the right team to help me make a comeback to the Indian side.

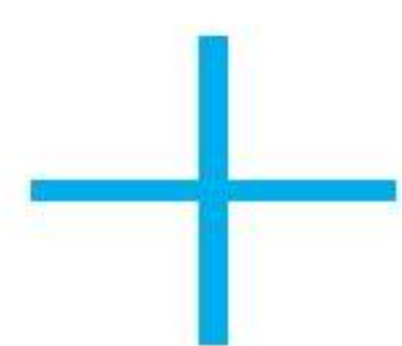
At 32, the next four to five years are likely my peak, so I wanted a team that provides opportunities. I'm

happy to move from one top franchise, Chennai Super Kings, to another, Mumbai Indians. Watching the auction, I was focused on the opportunity, not the money.

Mumbai Indians signed you for Rs 9.25 crore. Does the price tag affect you? How do you handle the pressure?

The price tag doesn't matter. My goal has always been to win games, whether I was signed for less or for Rs 14 crore by CSK in 2022.

When you play for a team for a long time, they understand your strengths and weaknesses, but when you shift to a new team, it's basically starting from scratch. I aim to



After IPL, I trained in the UK with a top football club for 12 weeks, focusing on improving my lower-body strength, which has been a concern in the past.